

Moonsea Rising - 20240615

Dinner at the Ironclaw's

As butlers and servants welcome the party into Baron Ironclaw's, he introduces the party to the others already in attendance:

- Terrian El Gata, fabulous merchant
- Doran Ma, fantastic person from Mulmaster
- Clemeth Faulk, associate on the Ironride Project
- Tomag Silverweave, a fine tailor
- Kia Kiulaudra, of House Caladra, pioneers of the relationship between Thar and Melvaunt
- Baroness Hermiphony Ironclaw, a talented iron-smith

As the party circulates during the drinks phase of the evening, Betris approaches Clemeth to talk more about the Ironride. Her Marsk blood throbs at the thought of extracting some kind of pecuniary reward from what Clemeth is working on. She finds that Clemeth is deeply invested in the relationship between Melvaunt and Thar, and isn't a fan of obsequious flattery. Lirael speaks to the Baron, finding out that his hobby is demonology, and he's published scholarly works on them. He lets slip that the Kingdom of Thar is a major investory in rail project. Lennox follows Beitris, enthusiastic about the construction of the train. Clemeth is happy with so much attention to the project, and tells them that the gems which power the spells are so valuable that the locomotive is a major bandit target.

Harken talks to Kia and Terrian, making small talk and trying to encourage him to simply loosen his tongue. He makes a couple of cryptic remarks about access to credit in the Moonsea, and finds that the man considers it a backwards region in which to do high-level business. Taevyn sees Kia Kiulaudra as closest to his age and station, and starts trying to chat to her about the party and dancing.

Beitris talks to Clemeth about the value of security measures for the train, to help allay her concerns about banditry. She suggests a variety of screening and security measures. Clemeth lights up on this point, and calls the Baron over to share Beitris' ideas. They are both interested in the idea that possibly the group might be useful in securing the train. Finding that to be well in hand, Lirael drifts over to the Baroness, talkign to her about her ironworks. She tells Lirael that's she's invented a form of steel that is extremely resistant to magic, while also being very conductive. Rather than wheels, the train will be using that technology for the rail. She's pleased that Thar has seen fit to invest so much in her work.

Lennox continues talking about railway security, and suggests employing the arena fighters as bulls to secure both the train and the stations, possibly as a trans-national security force, controlled by the rail company. Clemeth and the Baron are both impressed by this idea. Harken, feigning stomach issues to cover for his future needs to skip dinner. Watching everything that's going on, he notes Terrian seems frustrated by his inability to speak to the Baron alone, which Tomag

seems quite put out by Taevyn's interest in Kia Kiulaudra, and not subtly. He also catches Doran Ma's eye, as the man seems to be doing the same thing.

When a particular air starts up, Taevyn very formally invites Kia to dance with him. She takes him up on his offer, and is impressed by his dancing, though Tomag seems rather more upset than before. Beitris continues to talk to the Baron about rail security, and he confides that he's most concerned about organized political resistance, including from the Iron Fist -- whom he goes on at length about, Uriah the Fist, Nikolai the Bloody, red face-paint representing the orcish blood they've spilled, and their genocidal motto, "from Galaina, to Moonsea," about killing all the orcs. They have killed thousands of orcs. Most other impediments can be bought off or turned aside, but the Iron Fist is different.

Lirael comes up to the Baron and tries to make some room for him to talk to Terrian El Gata. The Baron is clearly visibly appreciative of Lirael's appearance, and Harken notices the Baroness catching his gaze. Lennox talks to Clemeth about her dietary ideas, looking for an advantage in the arena. She explains to him about breads and beers, and how the reduce healing. He nods along, mentally crossing things off his list.

Harken tries to convince the Baroness that escorting the Baron to speak to Terrian might get him away from Lirael, to which she's receptive. Pushing past Lirael, she directs the two to the corner, turning others away from them. Taevyn continues flattering Kia, oblivious to the happenings in the rest of the room.

Beitris drifts over to Doran Ma, asking him if he's enjoying the show so far. With a smile and wink he tells her he's not sure who is going to explode first, Tomag or Hermiphony. He tells her she's quite perceptive, and his consulting of the cards told him he would meet someone interesting tonight, but he didn't expect it to be a Cleric of Lathander. She tells him she's the, "other sort of cleric." He asks why she's present, given her family's feelings, and sympathizes that he, as a Thayan, is also often misapprehended by those around him. Lirael makes her way to Hermiphony to apologize for any perceived slight, and tell her that she had sensed that Terrian might have been interested in the economic potential of "her" railway. Hermiphony sees the sincerity in the apology, and relents on her position. She confides in Lirael that Terrian's association with the Zhentarim is worrying, and that they might try and steal the technology and take over the development from Thar. Lennox, sensing the mood lightening, comes over to the pair to ask more about the smelting and development of the magical steel. She tells him that the secret to Ironclaw steel is a special ore they found beneath Xul'jarak, which has as a vein of some kind of unusual material. He makes a passing remark about not revealing that information to anyone who wasn't part of the conversation, or who has been to the temple. She becomes very interested in that, asking if he has been to Xul'jarak, and he becomes evasive and tongue-tied. She is suspicious, but leaves it be for the moment.

Harken passes by Terrian and tells him, he hopes he's enjoying his discussion with the Baron, to which the merchant agrees. Taevyn rather nervously tries to flatter Kia and tries to find out what she knows about the Iron Fist. She notes that he calls them "freedom fighters" rather than "terrorists" or a "genocidal cult." He claims to try to reserve judgement. She begins rhetorically interrogating him, trying to figure why he might be sympathetic to anti-orcish sentiment. He learns that Uriah's wife and son were killed, marching against the orcs.

Beitris asks Doran Ma if he's a member of House Moje. Anger flashes briefly across his features, and he excuses himself quickly, leaving the party. Lirael asks Hermiphony why Lord Silverweave is present, and if she'd considered the potential of her steel in tandem with his TrueSilk™. She says that he was there almost solely because they were trying to make a match for Kia Kiulaudra. Lirael suggests that perhaps Taevyn might help him make up his mind. She turns back to Lennox, continuing her line of questioning about Xul'jurak. He manages to tell her something approximating the truth, and her gaze snaps back to Lirael as she whispers, "the chosen one!"

Lirael, meanwhile, moves to Taevyn to warn him about Tomag's reputation and interest. He is dismissive of any threat the man might pose, and thinks he's not Kia's type. She tells him to be careful, regardless. Harken moves to Tomag and tells him that Taevyn will mess it all up, and he doesn't need to lower himself to compete with the young man. Tomag is dismissive and uninterested in Harken's input. He starts striding toward Taevyn, who is dancing by himself on the floor, still trying to make eyes at Kia. She is getting more uncomfortable by the minute.

Beitris goes to Baron Ironclaw to apologize for Doran Ma's departure, mortified that whatever she said caused him to depart. He's moved by her words, and brings out a jeweled box, containing a card from War for the Crown. He offers her one of the special copies, representing The Zhent. Beitris is completely caught off guard, and thanks the Baron effusively. He mentions that he overheard her conversation with Ma, and notes that Laronen's reputation as one of the most murderous mages in recent memory might have been what set the man off.

Lirael moves to intercept Tomag before he approaches Taevyn and suggests that approaching Kia might work better to his advantage than engaging Taevyn. She attempts to use her magic to amplify the suggestion, and while he doesn't succumb to the spell, the logic of her position is clear to him, and he stalks off to the food with minor notes of gratitude. Lennox continues to talk to Clemeth about diet and exercise. She tells him that drinking water in equal quantity to beer helps mitigate the worst of the impact. Harken moves to Hermiphony, thanking her for her hospitality, and complimenting the food and company. The Baroness excitedly calls Clemeth over, telling Harken that she's convinced that the party might well have been "chosen" to be the one's to help them with the railroad project. She invites them all back to tea the next day to discuss the possibilities.

As the night draws to a close, Taevyn approaches Kia Kiulaudra, telling her all the dancing helps him think. He tells her that he thinks she agrees that they've made a connection, and that they're staying at the Cock and Bull. He asks if she might be free the next day to meet up for a meal. She tells him her schedule is quiet busy, but suggests he's welcome to join her and her friends at the gladiatorial games next week. He happily responds, "oh, great! It's a date then!"